

**SOCIAL GASLIGHTING AND EPISTEMIC MANIPULATION IN
PATRIARCHAL SYSTEMS: A CASE STUDY OF THE FILM *DON'T WORRY
DARLING* (2022)**

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ABSTRACT: This study explores the phenomenon of social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation within the framework of a patriarchal system, focusing on the film *Don't Worry Darling* (2022). Using qualitative methods and critical discourse analysis, this study investigates how patriarchal power in the film's narrative functions to discredit women's experiences, perceptions, and truths through organized epistemic strategies. Theories of social gaslighting (Abramson, 2014; Caplan, 2021) and epistemic manipulation (Fricker, 2007) are applied to understand the dynamics of control and truth obfuscation experienced by the female protagonist in the film. The findings of the analysis show that gaslighting not only occurs at the interpersonal level but also functions as a systemic tool that reinforces male dominance and suppresses women's agency. The results of this study expand our understanding of how control over knowledge and subjective reality can function as a form of symbolic violence in gender-unequal social structures. The film *Don't Worry Darling* (2022) serves as a significant cultural commentary that critiques the mechanisms of patriarchal control through the lens of social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation. This research highlights the importance of epistemic resistance and the restoration of women's agency within feminist criticism of patriarchal hegemony in popular cultural representations.

KEYWORDS: Social gaslighting, Epistemic manipulation, Patriarchy, Feminist epistemology, *Don't Worry Darling*, Symbolic violence

Introduction

The phenomenon of gaslighting has become a major focus in contemporary social and feminist studies, where it is understood as a form of psychological manipulation aimed at undermining an individual's perception of reality, particularly that of women, within the context of unequal power relations. Gaslighting does not only occur in interpersonal relationships but also operates systemically within patriarchal social structures, through what is referred to as social gaslighting (Ruíz, 2020). This practice blurs the boundaries between reality and illusion and negates women's epistemic authority, thereby reinforcing male dominance in social and cultural systems. In this context, gaslighting functions as a tool to maintain the existing gender hierarchy, where women's voices and experiences are often ignored or doubted. The film *Don't Worry Darling* (2022) provides a powerful representation for analyzing how social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation are used as instruments of patriarchal control. The film depicts a simulated utopian world that turns out to be a hidden dystopia, where women are forced to accept a false narrative that erases their agency and critical consciousness (Lorenzo et al., 2024). In the film's narrative, patriarchal power does not rely solely on physical force but primarily on epistemic power: who is deemed knowledgeable, trustworthy, and entitled to speak (McKinnon, 2016). This creates an environment where women are not only deprived of their freedom but also of their ability to understand and interpret their own experiences.

Gaslighting in a cultural context, or *cultural gaslighting*, has been recognized as a mechanism used to maintain the status quo by obscuring women's collective experiences (Ruíz, 2020). In the case of *Don't Worry Darling*, gaslighting is not only directed at the main character as an individual, but also as part of a system that normalizes women's submission to a male-controlled structure of reality. Through the film's narrative, it is evident that epistemic injustice occurs when women are doubted regarding their cognitive capabilities and the validity of their testimony. This epistemic injustice creates a deeper gap between women's subjective experiences and social recognition of those experiences.

Furthermore, *Don't Worry Darling* also shows how nostalgia for the “Old order” of patriarchy is repackaged as a form of social security and stability that actually hides repression against women (Booker

& Daraiseh, 2025). This representation aligns with Griessel & Kotzé's (2022) findings that postmodern women's narratives often become trapped in regressive psychological patterns under cultural pressures demanding conformity and self-denial. In this context, the film serves not only as entertainment but also as a profound social critique of patriarchal norms still deeply rooted in society. Therefore, it is important to view this film not merely as a work of fiction but as a reflection of the epistemic tensions in post-society, where the struggle over meaning, truth, and women's agency continues intensely. In this context, the film *Don't Worry Darling* functions as a mirror, reflecting broader social realities in which women struggle to reclaim their voices and authority in narratives often dominated by men. Using critical discourse analysis and feminist epistemological theory, this article examines how social gaslighting and epistemological manipulation operate within the narrative of *Don't Worry Darling*, as well as how forms of epistemological resistance are possible efforts to reclaim women's authority over their own experiences and truths. This research is expected to contribute to a deeper understanding of the dynamics of power in popular cultural representations and highlight the importance of feminist criticism in addressing the challenges faced by women in the modern era.

This film effectively depicts how social gaslighting operates in a patriarchal context. In *Don't Worry Darling*, the main character, Alice, is trapped in a world that seems ideal, but is actually a prison built by patriarchal narratives. When Alice begins to question the reality around her, she is met with denial and skepticism from those around her, reflecting how women are often doubted when they try to express their experiences and truths. This shows that gaslighting is not only individual but also a broader social phenomenon that serves to maintain patriarchal power. The visual representation in this film also plays an important role in conveying the theme of gaslighting. The use of color, lighting, and image composition creates a tense and suffocating atmosphere, reflecting the uncertainty experienced by the main character. The symbolism used in the film, such as mirrors and enclosed spaces, depicts Alice's struggle to find her truth and identity amid constant manipulation. Thus, the film conveys its message not only through dialogue but also through visual elements that reinforce the themes of gaslighting and epistemic manipulation.

The gender dynamics in *Don't Worry Darling* also reflect the injustices experienced by women in patriarchal societies. The film shows how women are often forced to conform to norms set by men, which in turn deprives them of their agency and freedom. In this context, gaslighting serves as a tool to maintain male control and dominance, where women are forced to accept narratives that do not align with their experiences. This creates tension between the desire for independence and the pressure to conform to existing norms. Although the film depicts many of the challenges faced by women, it also shows the potential for resistance and the restoration of agency. Alice, as the main character, struggles to find the truth and regain control over her life. This process reflects the journey of many women in dealing with gaslighting and epistemic manipulation in real life. By highlighting Alice's struggle, the film offers hope that women can find the strength within themselves to fight oppression and reclaim their voices.

Thus, *Don't Worry Darling* is not just an entertaining film, but also a work rich in social and political meaning. Through its analysis of social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation, the film provides deep insights into how women struggle to regain their voice and authority in a patriarchal society. This research is expected to contribute to a broader understanding of power dynamics in popular cultural representations and highlight the importance of feminist criticism in addressing the challenges faced by women in the modern era. As such, the film serves as a mirror for society to reflect on and address the issues of gender inequality that persist.

Abramson's Gaslighting Theory

Olivia Wilde's film *Don't Worry Darling* (2022) presents a narrative rich in themes of gaslighting and epistemic manipulation, which can be analyzed through two important theories: the theory of gaslighting proposed by Kate Abramson (2014) and the critique of psychological norms expressed by Paula Caplan (2012). Both provide a relevant framework for understanding how patriarchal power operates in this film and how women, particularly the main character Alice, struggle to reclaim their truth and agency. Kate Abramson (2014) in her article "Turning up the lights on gaslighting" explains gaslighting as a form of psychological manipulation that aims to cast doubt on an individual's perceptions and experiences, thereby creating uncertainty and confusion. Abramson emphasizes that gaslighting does not only occur in the context of interpersonal relationships but can also operate in broader social contexts where norms and power structures support such practices.

In *Don't Worry Darling*, we see how the character Alice experiences systemic gaslighting. She lives in a seemingly ideal society, but it is actually a prison built by patriarchal narratives. When Alice begins

to question the reality around her, she is met with denial and doubt from those around her, reflecting how gaslighting functions to maintain patriarchal control.

Caplan's Critique of Psychological Norms

Paula Caplan (2012), in her book *They Say You're Crazy: How the World's Most Powerful Psychiatrists Decide Who's Normal*, criticizes how psychological norms are often used to discredit women's experiences and reinforce male power. Caplan points out that mental health professionals often play a role in enforcing harmful social norms, where women who express dissatisfaction or doubt about their reality are often labeled as “crazy” or “abnormal.” In the context of *Don't Worry Darling*, we can see how the character Alice, when she begins to question the world around her, is met with stigma and doubt from those around her. This creates additional pressure that reinforces the gaslighting she experiences, where she is not only doubted by her husband but also by society at large.

The Connection Between the Two Theories

The connection between Abramson and Caplan's theories is evident in the narrative of *Don't Worry Darling*. Both highlight how gaslighting functions as a tool to maintain patriarchal power, both through direct psychological manipulation (Abramson, 2024) and through social norms that discredit women's experiences (Caplan, 1995). In the film, Alice struggles to uncover the truth and reclaim agency over her life, but she is confronted with a system that not only doubts her perceptions but also stigmatizes her dissatisfaction.⁶ Thus, *Don't Worry Darling* serves as a mirror reflecting a broader social reality, where women struggle to reclaim their voices and authority in narratives often dominated by men. Through this analysis, we can understand how gaslighting and psychological norms interact to create an oppressive environment, as well as the importance of resistance and the restoration of women's agency in the face of these challenges.

Discussion

The film *Don't Worry Darling*, directed by Olivia Wilde, presents a complex narrative about social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation in a patriarchal context. Through an analysis that combines Kate Abramson's (2014) theory of gaslighting and Paula Caplan's (2012) critique of psychological norms, we can understand how this film reflects and critiques power structures that oppress women, as listed below:

1. Gaslighting as a Tool of Control

Abramson (2014) explains that gaslighting serves to undermine an individual's perceptions, creating deep uncertainty. In *Don't Worry Darling*, the character Alice (Florence Pugh) experiences systemic gaslighting, where she is forced to doubt her own reality. As Alice begins to question the seemingly ideal world around her, she is met with denial and skepticism from her husband, Jack (Harry Styles), and society. A key moment occurs when Alice asks:

“None of this is real, is it?”

Jack replies, “Alice, honey, of course it's real. Everything here is real.”

(00:45:00–00:55:00)

This dialogue reflects what Abramson identifies as *interference in reality-testing*, where the gaslighter directly contradicts the victim's perceptions. Jack's denial, delivered in a gentle tone, creates the gaslighting paradox described by Sweet (2019) using seemingly caring attention to undermine Alice's epistemic trust. This demonstrates how gaslighting is not only interpersonal but also institutionalized within broader social structures, where women are often doubted and dismissed.

2. Psychological Norms and Stigma

Caplan (2012) criticizes how psychological norms are often used to discredit women's experiences. In this film, when Alice begins to express dissatisfaction with her reality, she is questioned not only by her husband but also by society at large. Dr. Collins, the psychologist in the film, states:

“What you're experiencing is completely normal... Just morning sickness and a wandering imagination.”

(00:25:00–00:30:00)

This statement shows how medical authority pathologizes Alice's accurate perceptions, applying what Caplan criticizes as the psychiatric normalization of women's dissatisfaction. This pseudo-scientific language, such as “morning sickness,” is used to enforce compliance, reflecting the framework of epistemic oppression outlined by Berenstain (2020). In this way, the film illustrates how the medical system can function as a tool to uphold patriarchal norms, where women's experiences are often deemed invalid.

3. The Connection Between Gaslighting and Epistemic Injustice

The connection between gaslighting and epistemic injustice is also highly relevant in the analysis of this film. McKinnon (2016) and Carel & Kidd (2014) explain that epistemic injustice occurs when women are doubted in terms of their cognitive capabilities and the validity of their testimony. In *Don't Worry Darling*, Alice experiences this injustice as she struggles to prove the truth of her experiences. This epistemic injustice creates a deeper gap between women's subjective experiences and social recognition of those experiences, which aligns with Ruíz's (2020) view of *cultural gaslighting*. The film shows how Victory, a seemingly ideal society, is actually an oppressive dystopia. When Alice tries to share her experiences, she is often met with doubt and rejection, which further reinforces the epistemic injustice she experiences. This creates an environment where women's voices and experiences are not only ignored but also doubted.

4. Nostalgia and the Reproduction of Patriarchy

Furthermore, the film also depicts how nostalgia for the “old order” of patriarchy is repackaged as a form of social security and stability. Booker and Daraïseh (2025) show that the film criticizes the nostalgic cultural logic that often masks the repression of women. In this context, *Don't Worry Darling* serves as a critique of patriarchal norms that are still deeply rooted in society, where women are forced to conform to the expectations set by men. This nostalgia is evident in the film's visual aesthetic, which adopts an idealized 1950s style. However, behind this beauty lies an oppressive reality. Victory society serves as an allegory for how patriarchal norms are often disguised as traditions that must be respected, when in fact they are tools for maintaining control.

5. Restoring Resilience and Capacity to Act

Although the film depicts many of the challenges faced by women, it also shows the potential for resistance and restoration of agency. Alice, as the main character, struggles to find the truth and regain control over her life. In the climactic moment, she declares:

“I see everything now. The whole fucking ugly truth.”

(00:90:00)

This statement reflects what Kidd & Carel (2017) refer to as *epistemic resistance*, marking the return of Alice's interpretive authority. The coarse language sharply contrasts with the subtle euphemisms used by the community, signifying her rejection of what Overell (2024) calls *patriarchal epistemic decorum*.

Through Alice's journey, the film shows that although women are often trapped in oppressive systems, they have the ability to fight back and reclaim their voices. This process is not only important for Alice's character, but also reflects the struggles of many women in the real world who are trying to overcome gaslighting and oppression.

Conclusion

The film *Don't Worry Darling* (2022) serves as a significant cultural commentary that critiques

the mechanisms of patriarchal control through the lens of social gaslighting and epistemic manipulation. By utilizing the theories of Abramson, Caplan, and Fricker, this analysis illustrates how the film portrays not only personal psychological manipulation but also systemic practices that undermine women's experiences and their authority in knowledge. The character of Alice embodies a struggle for epistemic recognition, with her transition from confusion to awareness mirroring broader feminist issues regarding truth, authority, and agency within gendered power dynamics. Through a critical discourse analysis, this research reveals that gaslighting in the film acts as a form of symbolic violence, subtly manifesting through language, visual elements, and institutional frameworks such as healthcare and societal norms. Alice's defiance and the eventual reclamation of her voice underscore the significance of epistemic resilience as a feminist response to patriarchal oppression. Thus, the film not only serves as entertainment but also prompts critical examination of how narratives, authority, and knowledge are shaped and contested in modern society. In conclusion, *Don't Worry Darling* (2022) provides a pertinent critique of the epistemic injustices that women continue to encounter, while highlighting the pressing need for feminist resistance to reclaim interpretive power and challenge dominant narratives. This study reinforces the idea that cultural texts can significantly contribute to revealing and resisting the subtle workings of patriarchal ideology in everyday life.

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